man and recruit him, he turned out to be the most important spy that the Indian agency ever had in Nepal.

KI36 provided Garg with information on all the Pakistani nationals arriving in the country, allowing the Indians to peep into the files of Pakistani officials, tourists and businessmen moving in and out of Nepal. The spies worked via the age-old system of making drops at particular places, signalling the necessity for pick up with signs such as the '+' mark. In late 1972, Garg and the other operatives launched an operation in which Pakistani agents masquerading as businessmen were exposed and nabbed. They had been tailed for days by Garg's team and had revealed their true identities and details of a meeting they had held with rebel groups to launch an attack inside Nepal, aiming to put the blame on India. It was a risky operation, but Garg was determined to neutralise the plot.

Meanwhile, the Indian government faced some hard truths in the domain of its diplomatic relationship with Nepal. The R&AW's role was limited to preventing anti-India activities in Nepal and ensuring the country's policies were in favour of New Delhi and not Beijing and Islamabad. However, a US embassy report on 19 December 1973 from New Delhi observed that the friction in the Indo-Nepalese relationship could get worse, as India increasingly worried about the friendliness between Nepal and China.

India had consistently maintained that Nepal was within its security frontiers; any establishment of the Chinese in the Himalayan country would mean that Beijing had easy access to India's heartland across the porous five-hundred-mile border with Nepal. Concerns were raised that the Chinese embassy in Kathmandu was assisting the Maoists in India.